



TOOLBOX TALK — WEEKLY SAFETY MEETING

Millwork | Carpentry | Interior Finishes | Material Handling

WEEK 05

Date: Supervisor:

Project / Job Name:

TOPIC: Table Saw Safety & Anti-Kickback Procedures

OVERVIEW:

The table saw is responsible for more serious injuries in woodworking and millwork than almost any other machine. The primary hazard — kickback — happens in a fraction of a second and can send a workpiece back at the operator at speeds exceeding 100 miles per hour. Understanding why kickback

TALKING POINTS — Read to Crew:

1. Kickback occurs when the blade catches the trailing edge of a workpiece and launches it back toward the operator. It happens most often when the wood pinches the blade — usually because the kerf closes as internal stresses in the wood release during the cut. The riving knife is the single most important device for preventing kickback because it keeps the kerf open behind the blade. Never
2. Your body position at the table saw is as important as any guard. Never stand directly behind the blade in line with the potential path of a kicked-back piece. Position yourself to the left or right of the blade line. If kickback occurs and you are not in line with the blade, the workpiece passes by you rather than into you. This one habit has saved countless injuries.
3. The anti-kickback pawls and blade guard are not optional equipment. They are safety devices that exist because people died without them. If your saw's guards are missing, damaged, or removed, stop using the saw and report it. There is no valid production reason to remove blade guards for ripping operations. Push sticks and push blocks must be used for any rip cut narrower than 6 inches.
4. Never perform a freehand cut on a table saw — always use the rip fence or the miter gauge to guide the cut. Never use both the fence and the miter gauge simultaneously — this creates a pinch point that causes kickback. Make sure the blade is sharp. A dull blade requires more feed force, generates more heat, and dramatically increases the chance of a kickback event.

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS — Ask Your Crew:

Q1: Has anyone experienced or witnessed a kickback on a table saw? What happened?

Q2: What do we do if we discover a table saw with guards removed or damaged?

KEY SAFETY POINTS:

- Stand to the side of the blade line, never directly behind the blade
- Never reach over or behind a spinning blade for any reason
- Use a push stick or push block for all rips narrower than 6 inches
- Let the blade reach a complete stop before reaching near it
- Never perform freehand cuts — always use the fence or miter gauge

Crew sign-in sheet on page 2 — all 30 crew members sign on the following page.



CREW SIGN-IN SHEET

WEEK 05

By signing, I confirm I attended this toolbox talk and understand the topic discussed.

#	PRINT NAME	SIGNATURE (click to sign in Acrobat)	#	PRINT NAME	SIGNATURE (click to sign in Acrobat)
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